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MAHATMA GANDHI UNIVERSITY, KOTTAYAM

MGU-UGP (HONOURS) REGULAR EXAMINATION March 2026

Fourth SEMESTER

Discipline Specific Core Course (DSC) - MG4DSCJMC202 - MEDIA ANDCOMMUNICATION ETHICS

Duration: 2 hours **Maximum Marks: 70**

PART A — Multiple Choice Questions

1b) Deontology

2c) Values

3d) All of these

4b) Objectivity

5c) Deal between media and corporates where the media gets equity shares in exchange for positive news coverage

6d) All of these

7d) By creating a misleading impression for audiences

8c) Paywall

9a) Substantiation

10a) Truthful, non-deceptive, fair, and socially responsible

PART B — Short Answer Questions *(3 Marks)*

11. Explain the central features of the concept of external accountability.

- External accountability refers to the mechanisms through which media organisations and journalists are held responsible for their conduct by bodies and institutions outside the organisation itself
- It includes regulatory bodies such as the Press Council of India, courts, ombudsmen, and audience watchdog groups that evaluate media performance against established ethical and legal standards
- External accountability complements internal editorial standards by providing independent oversight, ensuring that media organisations do not operate without public consequence for ethical violations or inaccurate, harmful reporting

12. Write a short note on PCI's ethical guidelines for journalists

- The Press Council of India's Norms of Journalistic Conduct require journalists to maintain accuracy, fairness, and impartiality in reporting, and to correct errors promptly and prominently
- Guidelines prohibit the publication of unverified information, sensationalism, invasion of privacy, identification of rape survivors, and content that incites communal or religious hatred
- The PCI also mandates that journalists declare conflicts of interest, refrain from accepting gifts or favours that could compromise editorial independence, and ensure that advertisements are clearly distinguishable from editorial content

13. Describe the importance of media ethics in a democratic society

- Media ethics provides the normative framework that ensures journalism serves the public interest rather than commercial, political, or personal interests of media owners and journalists

- Ethical journalism — characterised by accuracy, fairness, independence, and accountability — is foundational to an informed citizenry capable of meaningful democratic participation
- Without ethical standards, media becomes vulnerable to manipulation, misinformation, and bias that erode public trust, distort political discourse, and undermine the press's constitutionally recognised role as a watchdog of democratic governance

14. Explain the role of ASCI in setting the professional standards advertising industry.
    - The Advertising Standards Council of India (ASCI) is a self-regulatory body that establishes and enforces ethical standards for advertising across all media platforms in India
    - Its Code for Self-Regulation requires advertisements to be truthful, non-offensive, not harmful to society, and fair in competition — prohibiting misleading claims, indecent content, and ads targeting children exploitatively
    - ASCI operates a Consumer Complaints Council that reviews complaints and directs advertisers to modify or withdraw advertisements found to violate its code, functioning as the primary non-governmental check on advertising ethics in India
15. Explain the two elements upon which professional ethics of journalism is founded
    - The first element is truth-telling — journalism's foundational obligation to report facts accurately, verify information through credible sources, and present a truthful account of events to the public
    - The second element is independence — journalists must be free from commercial, political, and personal pressures that could compromise their ability to report impartially and in the public interest
    - Together, truth and independence form the ethical bedrock upon which journalism's credibility, democratic function, and public trust are constructed
16. Suggest at least three measures to prevent unethical practices such as bribery and junkets in media organizations
    - Establish and enforce a clear editorial policy that prohibits journalists from accepting gifts, cash, free travel, or hospitality from sources, organisations, or PR agencies covering beats they report on
    - Require mandatory disclosure of any potential conflicts of interest — including free products received for review — and publish these disclosures transparently alongside relevant content
    - Implement institutional whistleblower mechanisms that allow journalists and staff to report unethical practices by colleagues or management without fear of retaliation, reinforcing a culture of accountability within the organisation
17. Explain the need of source confidentiality in reporting
    - Source confidentiality — the journalist's ethical and legal commitment to protect the identity of sources who provide information on condition of anonymity — is essential to investigative and accountability journalism
    - Without guaranteed confidentiality, whistleblowers, insiders, and vulnerable sources would be unwilling to share information about corruption, abuse of power, or wrongdoing, severely limiting journalism's watchdog function
    - Breach of source confidentiality exposes sources to professional, legal, or physical harm, destroys journalist credibility, and sets a precedent that discourages future sources from coming forward with information of public importance
18. What is objectivity of journalistic method?
    - Objectivity of journalistic method refers to the procedural commitment to gathering, verifying, and presenting information through a disciplined, transparent process that minimises personal bias rather than claiming a bias-free perspective

- It involves seeking multiple sources, presenting competing viewpoints fairly, separating fact from opinion, and being transparent about the basis of reported claims
- Originally conceived as a scientific approach to reporting, journalistic objectivity is now understood as an aspirational standard and methodological discipline rather than an achievable state of complete neutrality

19. Define plagiarism in journalism.

- Plagiarism in journalism is the act of using another journalist's, author's, or source's words, ideas, reporting, or creative work without proper attribution, presenting it as one's own original work
- It constitutes a serious ethical violation that breaches intellectual property rights, deceives audiences, and undermines the credibility of both the individual journalist and the publication
- Forms of journalistic plagiarism include lifting quotes from other publications without credit, reproducing news agency copy without attribution, and paraphrasing another reporter's exclusive findings without acknowledgement

20. Define conflict of interest in the context of advertising and editorial content

- A conflict of interest in the advertising-editorial relationship arises when commercial considerations — advertiser relationships, revenue dependency, or equity arrangements — influence the content, tone, or placement of editorial coverage
- This occurs when journalists or editors favour, avoid criticising, or provide positive coverage of advertisers, compromising the editorial independence that distinguishes journalism from public relations
- Private treaties — arrangements where media houses receive equity stakes in companies in exchange for favourable coverage — are a prominent contemporary example of institutionalised conflict of interest that fundamentally compromises editorial integrity

21. State any three principles from the PRSI's Code of Ethics for Public Relations inIndia

- PR professionals must deal honestly and fairly with clients, employers, and the public, ensuring that all communication is truthful and not deliberately misleading
- Members must safeguard the confidentiality of clients' information and avoid using privileged information for personal gain or to the detriment of clients
- PR practitioners must not engage in practices that corrupt the integrity of channels of public communication, including offering undisclosed payments to journalists or media personnel in exchange for favourable coverage

22. Define the term spin in public relations

- Spin refers to the strategic framing, selective presentation, or favourable interpretation of information by PR professionals to manage public perception of an individual, organisation, or event
- Unlike straightforward communication, spin involves emphasising positives, downplaying negatives, and controlling narrative context to shape audience understanding in ways that serve the client's interests
- Spin is ethically contested — while strategic framing is a legitimate PR tool, spin that involves deception, suppression of material facts, or deliberate misleading of the public crosses into ethically problematic territory

PART C — Essay Questions *(15 Marks)*

23. Explain the role of media as the fourth estate

- The Fourth Estate concept positions the press as an informal but constitutionally significant institution that operates alongside and independently of the three formal estates of government — legislature, executive, and judiciary — to hold power accountable

- The term is attributed to Edmund Burke and was later popularised by Thomas Carlyle, reflecting the historical recognition that a free press is indispensable to democratic governance and civil liberty
- The media fulfils its Fourth Estate function through investigative reporting that exposes corruption and abuse of power, through agenda-setting that places public interest issues before policymakers, and through providing citizens with the information necessary for democratic participation
- In India, landmark investigative journalism — from the Bofors scandal coverage to the 2G spectrum scam reporting — demonstrates the press's capacity to trigger legislative scrutiny, judicial intervention, and public accountability. But, Fourth Estate ideal is threatened by increasing media ownership concentration, commercial pressures, political partisanship, and the rise of entertainment-driven content that displaces public interest journalism. The digital age has both empowered and complicated the Fourth Estate function — citizen journalism and social media have expanded the information ecosystem, while algorithmic platforms, misinformation, and attention economy pressures challenge the press's ability to perform its democratic accountability role responsibly and sustainably

24. List the types of primary and secondary sources and the ways in which they impact the weight of a story

- Primary sources are direct, firsthand sources of information — including eyewitnesses, official documents, data, court records, government reports, scientific studies, and on-record interviews with key stakeholders
- Primary sources carry the greatest evidentiary weight in journalism because they provide direct access to facts, making stories more credible, legally defensible, and resistant to challenge
- Types of primary sources include named officials, victim testimonies, corporate filings, police FIRs, legislative records, medical reports, and original research data
- Secondary sources interpret, analyse, or report on primary source material — including academic commentary, expert analysis, previously published journalism, and historical records
- Secondary sources add context, background, and analytical depth to stories but carry less evidentiary weight than primary sources and must themselves be verified for accuracy and credibility
- The balance between primary and secondary sources determines a story's overall journalistic authority — a story built entirely on secondary sources is vulnerable to factual error, while integration of strong primary sources with expert secondary commentary produces the most credible, contextually rich journalism

25. Describe the ethical responsibilities involved in data visualization. Why are accuracy and clarity important when presenting visual data

- Application level.

26. Describe the importance of verification in online journalism, especially during breaking news situations

- Verification — the systematic process of confirming the accuracy of information through multiple independent sources before publication — is the most critical ethical obligation in online journalism, and its importance is intensified during breaking news situations where speed pressures are greatest
- The breaking news environment creates acute tension between the competitive imperative to publish first and the journalistic responsibility to publish accurately; ethical online journalism requires that this tension always be resolved in favour of accuracy over speed
- Unverified breaking news published on digital platforms spreads with extraordinary speed through social media sharing, making corrections difficult to circulate as widely as the original error — the reputational and real-world harm caused by false breaking news can be severe and lasting
- Verification practices in online journalism include cross-referencing information with multiple independent sources, contacting official spokespersons, authenticating images and videos through reverse image search and metadata analysis, and using tools such as InVID and Google Fact Check.